Raj's position on Tibetan suzerainty within Chinese sovereignty as well as the McMahon Line border between India and Tibet delineated by the Simla Convention of 1914. But the People's Republic of China viewed Tibet as a fully sovereign territory that never enjoyed any right to make international treaties such as the Simla Convention.[18] When China annexed Tibet, India chose to pursue a mixed policy that combined cooperation with elements of internal balancing. Articulating the rationale for such a policy, Nehru argued that India would thereby be able to persuade China to permit Tibet to "retain a large measure of her autonomy" while maintaining the focus of its own defence policy on Pakistan, preventing the formation of a two-front threat, and limiting the defence burden.[19] At the same time, to ensure that China did not engage in cross-border infiltration and occupation of disputed territory, Nehru advocated improving communications, enhancing policing, and establishing control over the border regions. In sum, Nehru advocated a policy of cooperation with China, accompanied by measures to consolidate state control over the border regions.

Nehru's China policy consisted of three main features: securing the border, encouraging Tibet and China to negotiate the terms of Tibetan autonomy within the rubric of Chinese suzerainty, and forging an understanding with China. Securing the border was a top priority given Nehru's assessment that the threat from China was likely to manifest itself only in the form of cross-border infiltration, subversion of border populations, and occupation of unoccupied territory. At the time of independence, the border regions in the eastern and western sectors, that is, the North East Frontier Agency (NEFA) and Ladakh, were practically devoid of administration, communications, and development. In Ladakh, police and revenue administration were extended beyond Leh to places such as Zanskar and Thoise only after independence. In NEFA, "administration